Deadline-Constrained Scheduling of Multi-Mode Task Chains under Fail-Stop Failures

***Abstract*—Scheduling real-time applications in the presence of failures is challenging. In many domains, some level of output error is tolerable: application tasks offer different execution modes, where modes with longer execution times lead to lower error. This provides an opportunity for meeting real-time constraints in the presence of failures by trading off higher error for faster task executions. In this context, we study the problem of scheduling a chain of multi-mode tasks onto a failure-prone platform, allowing for replication, rollback/recovery, adaptive mode changes after failures, reuse of persistent intermediate outputs, and coordination across multiple processing elements. The objective is to minimize the expected error in the final output produced by a deadline, with a penalty if no output is produced. For the case in which the platform comprises a single processing element, we develop a dynamic program that computes optimal scheduling decisions for the time-discretized problem under the assumption that a task is never re-executed after it has successfully completed once. We also show how to select an appropriate discretization resolution in practice. When the platform comprises multiple processing elements, we propose various heuristics, several of which build on the above dynamic program. We demonstrate and/or evaluate our dynamic programming approach and heuristics via simulated executions for a fusion energy application derived from a production use case and for a large set of synthetic workloads.**

***Index Terms*—Fault tolerance, deadline-constrained scheduling, multi-mode task chains.**

I. Introduction

Executions on compute platforms are subject to hardware and software errors. An active area of research is application scheduling in the presence of failures in non-real-time [1] or real-time [2] settings, typically using rollback/recovery and/or computation replication techniques. In this work, we focus on deadline-constrained scientific computing applications, which are increasingly commonplace across the sciences (see a recent U.S. Department of Energy study [3]).

In many domains, approximate computing techniques [4] make it possible to implement application tasks with multiple *execution modes*. Each mode corresponds to a trade-off between execution time and output error, where an erroneous output retains some utility. Trading off output quality for a shorter execution time provides an opportunity to meet real-time deadlines that would otherwise be missed, motivating the development of strategies for scheduling approximate computing applications in the presence of failures [5]–[10].

In this work we consider an application structured as a chain of tasks, some of which have multiple modes of execution. The application executes on a platform comprised of one or more processing elements (PEs) and is subject to fail-stop failures. Given an end-to-end deadline, the objective is to make scheduling decisions that minimize the expected error of the best final output produced by that deadline, assigning a user-defined penalty when no final output is produced. Prior work [11] considers static replication and resource provisioning in this setting. Instead, we consider dynamic scheduling decisions that can employ replication, rollback/recovery, execution mode changes after failures, reuse of persistent intermediate outputs, and coordinated scheduling across PEs. Specifically, we make the following contributions:

- We formulate the problem and show its NP-hardness;
- For one-PE platforms we discretize time to develop a dynamic programming approach, together with a practical method for selecting the discretization resolution;
- For multiple-PE platforms we propose heuristics, some of which build on our results for the one-PE case; and
- We evaluate our scheduling strategies in simulation, both for a production workload from the field of fusion energy science and for a large set of synthetic workloads.

The rest of this paper is organized as follows. Section II details a production use case that motivates our scheduling problem, which is formalized in Section III. Section IV describes our experimental methodology. Sections V and VI present our approach and results for one-PE and multiple-PE platforms, respectively. Section VIII reviews related work. Finally, Section IX concludes with a brief summary of results and perspectives on future work.

II. Motivating Use Case

A current use case in the field of fusion energy science is presented in [11], where the objective is to operate reactors such as the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER). These reactors are equipped with sensors to monitor the state of the plasma and of the reactor itself. The sensor data can be processed for several real-time purposes, such as the steering of experiments between shots of the reactors, or the detection of catastrophic event precursors. This data is processed by applications structured as chains of tasks that perform data compression/decompression, data reduction/filtering, simulation, analysis, or visualization. These applications are executed periodically throughout the lifespan of the operation of the reactor, with results needed by the end of each period. Fig. 1 depicts a three-task chain for the specific application configuration described in [12].

For fault-tolerance purposes, the authors in [11] propose using approximate computing techniques to trade off output quality for shorter execution times. While many such techniques are available [4], [16], they focus on data size reduction

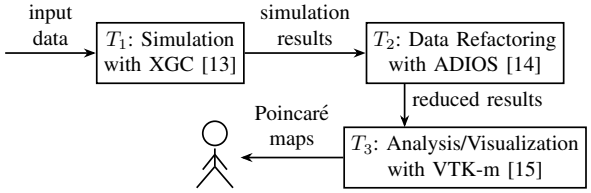


Fig. 1. Example three-task chain for a fusion energy science application [12].

using generic compression methods or methods specifically designed for scientific datasets [17]. Regardless, some or all of the tasks in the application come with different execution modes that correspond to, e.g., different compression factors, different data refactoring options, and different precision levels. The above use case provides the motivation for the formulation of the scheduling problem in the next section.

III. Problem Statement

A. Application Model

The application is a chain of $M \geq 1$ tasks. Each task T_i, $i=1,\ldots,M$, takes input data, performs a computation, and generates output data, as a three-step sequence. Each successful execution of T_i produces output data, any of which may be used as input by an execution of T_{i+1}. Data is always written to and read from stable storage. An "in-situ" execution in which the output data from a parent task remains in RAM and can be accessed by the child task without any I/O would simply amount to merging these two tasks into a single task.

Error in application data is tolerated: T_i offers $K_i \geq 1$ execution modes for different trade-offs between execution time and output error. T_i takes $x \in \mathbb{N}$ bytes of input with an error level $y \in [1, +\infty)$, where 1 denotes no error. We define execution mode j for T_i, $j=1,\ldots,K_i$, by three functions:

- $t_j^i(x,y)$: The compute time (not including I/O);
- $d_j^i(x,y)$: The size in bytes of the output data; and
- $e_j^i(x,y)$: The error level in the output data.

In practice, these functions may be independent of some of their inputs (see the example in Table I).

TABLE I
Example execution modes for a data compression task. x is the input data size in bytes and y is the input data error.

Execution mode	$t(x,y)$	$d(x,y)$	$e(x,y)$
no compression	0	x	y
slow lossless compression	$2+10x$	$x/10$	y
fast lossless compression	$1+5x$	$x/2$	y
fast lossy compression	$1+2x$	$x/20$	$3y/2$

Error propagates through inter-task data dependencies and accumulates end-to-end. Many previous works on the scheduling of real-time, approximate computing applications employ the "monotone" model by which a task can reduce the error in its input data by performing additional computation [7]. The above model can account for this error reduction behavior by defining the t and e functions appropriately. For the use cases that motivate this work, as that in Section II, there is no possibility of error reduction (i.e., $e_j^i(x,y) \geq y$).

The execution of the application must complete by a deadline, $D>0$. The *output error* is defined as the minimum error across the output data of all successful executions of T_M (the last task). If no execution of T_M has succeeded by the deadline, then the output error is set to e_f, a user-defined value that quantifies the penalty for returning no usable output by the deadline. The value of e_f is set to be larger than any achievable output error by a successful execution of T_M.

B. Platform and Fault Model

The platform comprises N homogeneous processing elements (PEs), that each can execute only one task at a time. A PE could be a single core that executes a sequential program, a multi-core host that executes a multi-threaded program, or a set of compute nodes that execute a parallel program. Each PE reads/writes task data on a parallel file system, with read bandwidth B_r and write bandwidth B_w. In practice, PEs can experience contention when accessing the parallel file system concurrently. While contention is part of our simulation model (for experiments), our analytical model assumes no contention so that analytical developments remain tractable.

Task executions on PEs experience fail-stop failures (failed task executions do not produce usable output data). Each PE is subject to independent failures with exponentially distributed inter-arrival times with rate λ ($\lambda=0$ corresponds to a failure-free system). Exponentially distributed failures are commonplace in the fault-tolerance literature due to their memoryless property. Although failures are not necessarily memoryless in real-world settings, assuming exponentially distributed failures remains sensible in practice [18]. We assume a single rate λ regardless of a task's execution mode. Some works consider different failure rates for different execution modes [5], [6], [9]. Considering different failure rates for different modes in this work would merely entail simple modifications to the recursive formulas presented in Section V-A.

Following a failure, the affected PE cannot resume computing for $R \geq 0$ seconds. This *restart overhead* corresponds to acquiring a spare host (due to a hardware failure), rebooting the host (due to an OS crash), or simply restarting a task (due to a software bug). As commonly done in the literature, we assume a single restart overhead and do not distinguish different types of failures. Here again, doing so would entail straightforward (if tedious) modifications to the recursive formulas presented in Section V-A.

A key technique to handle fail-stop failures is roll-back/recovery, by which a task is restarted if it fails [1]. A common question is that of whether and when a task should checkpoint its state to stable storage to avoid rolling back the entire computation when a failure occurs [19]. In this work checkpointing is built into the application because each task reads its input and saves its output to stable storage. Our model can easily be extended to consider a task that implements its own checkpointing: replace the task by a chain

of tasks, each of which corresponds to the execution between two checkpoints. All tasks in this chain, except the first, would read their input from stable storage only when restarted after a failure, which would require minor changes to the recursive formulas presented in Section V-A. Besides rollback/recovery, another key technique is replication, by which backup tasks are executed on different PEs to increase the chances that at least one replica will succeed [1]. In this work, we use both rollback/recovery and replication.

C. Scheduling Problem

We consider the problem of *minimizing the expected output error* for a single invocation of the application, released at time zero and subject to an end-to-end deadline D. As seen in our motivating use case in Section II, the application is intended to be invoked periodically. But successive invocations do not overlap, no unfinished work carries over beyond a deadline, and all PEs are available at the beginning of each invocation. Each invocation can thus be scheduled independently using the same strategy. In other words, only the deployment of the application is periodic, not its scheduling.

The scheduling problem is offline because application and platform specifications are known in advance. But because failures are stochastic, a scheduling strategy should be adaptive and make decisions that account for execution events at runtime. Therefore, we consider scheduling strategies that are invoked at time zero and also in response to task completions, task failures, and PEs becoming available. Scheduling decisions can consist of aborting current task executions (making PEs immediately available) or selecting which tasks to execute with which execution modes. We define an *optimal strategy* as one in which each decision minimizes the expected output error given the current state of the application execution and the time remaining until the deadline. The scheduling problem then is to determine an optimal strategy.

Proposition 1. *The above scheduling problem is NP-hard, even for a one-PE, failure-free platform with zero I/O costs, two modes per task, and zero restart overhead.*

Proof. With no failures, the execution is non-stochastic. All scheduling decisions can be made at time zero and, with one PE, we can restrict ourselves to strategies that execute each task exactly once with one mode. Let us prove the NP-completeness of the decision problem: does there exist a strategy that can achieve an output error of at most some threshold τ? The problem is in NP because, given the list of the chosen execution modes, one can compute the overall execution time and output error in polynomial time. We prove NP-completeness via a reduction from 0-1 KNAPSACK [20].

Consider an instance of 0-1 KNAPSACK with m items, where item $i{=}1,\ldots,m$ has weight w_i and value v_i. The knapsack capacity is W, and for $V{>}0$ we consider the problem of deciding whether a solution exists with total value $\geq V$. We construct an instance of our scheduling decision problem as follows. We consider an m-task chain in which task T_i, $i{=}1,\ldots,m$ has two execution modes: (i) *fast*: execution time $t(x,y){=}1$, output size $d(x,y){=}0$, and error $e(x,y){=}y{+}v_i$ (i.e., introduced additive error); and (ii) *slow*: execution time $t(x,y){=}1{+}w_i$, output size $d(x,y){=}0$, and error function $e(x,y){=}y$ (i.e., no introduced error). We set the deadline to $D{=}m{+}W$, the size of the initial input to 0, and the error of the initial input to 1. Let us define $\tau{=}1{+}V_\Sigma{-}V$, where $V_\Sigma{=}\sum_{i=1}^{m} v_i$. We consider the problem of deciding whether there exists a strategy for which the chain's output error is $\leq\tau$. We define $e_f{=}2{+}V_\Sigma$, so that a chain execution that does not complete by the deadline leads to error strictly greater than τ. This construction is computable in polynomial time.

Let S be the set of tasks that are executed with their slow execution mode, as decided by the strategy. The application execution finishes by deadline D when:

$$\sum_{i\notin S} 1 + \sum_{i\in S}(1+w_i) \leq m+W \text{ , i.e., when } \sum_{i\in S} w_i \leq W.$$

The chain's output error is:

$$1 + \sum_{i\notin S} v_i = 1 + V_\Sigma - \sum_{i\in S} v_i = \tau + V - \sum_{i\in S} v_i \ .$$

Therefore, the chain's output error is $\leq\tau$ if and only if $\sum_{i\in S} v_i \geq V$. In other words, the answer to the scheduling decision problem is yes if and only if the answer to the knapsack decision problem is yes, completing the reduction. □

IV. EXPERIMENTAL METHODOLOGY

Our simulator, application workloads, simulation results, and results processing scripts are publicly available [21].

A. Application Workloads

Some of our results are illustrated for the fusion science application in Fig. 1. Tasks T_1, T_2, and T_3 have four, four, and three execution modes, respectively, each described by affine t, d, and e functions. These particular execution modes and affine functions are based on results in [12] and on information provided to us by the authors.

We also evaluate heuristics over a large set of synthetic application configurations. A synthetic configuration is generated as follows. We randomly sample the number of tasks $M{\in}\{2,3,4,5\}$. For each task T_i we randomly sample its number of modes $K_i{\in}\{2,3,4\}$. We then generate a first "safe" (s) execution mode (fast, high error) and a last "risky" (r) execution mode (slow, low error) as follows, omitting arguments on which a function does not depend:

- $t_s^i{=}u_{50,600}$
- $d_s^i{=}\lceil u_{10^{10},10^{12}} \rceil$
- $e_s^i(y){=}u_{3,10}\cdot y$
- $t_r^i{=}u_{2\cdot t_s^i,6\cdot t_s^i}$
- $d_r^i{=}\lceil u_{0.01\cdot d_s^i,0.3\cdot d_s^i} \rceil$
- $e_r^i(y){=}u_{1,\min(0.6\cdot e_s^i(1),e_s^i(1)-0.5)}\cdot y$

where $u_{a,b}$ denotes a value sampled once from the uniform distribution on $[a,b] \subset \mathbb{R}$. Additional modes are generated between the safe and risky modes using linear equidistant interpolation. In practice, the t and d functions are likely non-constant (as in our fusion science use case). However, using constant functions, especially in the input size, makes it straightforward to generate a broad range of configurations in which no execution mode is trivially dominated by another.

The intervals for the uniform distribution are selected empirically to ensure that the application configurations are diverse enough that different scheduling algorithms can make a wide range of reasonable decisions. For each generated application configuration we compute p_s, resp. p_r, the probability that the execution on a single PE succeeds by the deadline when using only safe, resp. risky, execution modes. p_s and p_r are computed using dynamic programming (see Section V) using the same D, λ, R, B_r, and B_w values as that used in simulation. To eliminate trivially easy or hard cases, we filter out configurations with $p_s{<}0.15$, $p_s{>}0.85$, or $p_r{<}0.01$. The D and λ values merely establish a common time scale; failure behavior is driven by the overall application execution time relative to the deadline, D, and to the mean time between failures, $1/\lambda$. Our synthetic configurations do not aim to model any specific workload. Instead, they define a set of scenarios with different relative execution-time, data-size, and error magnitudes, over which different scheduling principles can be compared systematically.

B. Simulation Methodology

Our simulator builds on a simulation framework designed to model real-world software/hardware platforms, and in particular network and I/O operations, accurately. Scheduling works in the literature, like this one, typically use an abstract model of I/O operations, where transfer time is simulated as the data volume divided by some nominal bottleneck bandwidth, to render analytical developments and algorithm design tractable [22], [23]. Our simulator supports two I/O simulation modes. Its "model-consistent" mode enforces the above abstract model, and is used to validate our implementation. Its "realistic" mode uses realistic simulation models that account for protocol and contention effects. Unless specified otherwise, simulation results are obtained with the realistic mode. Each invocation of the simulator takes in a full specification of the scheduling problem, as well as a seed value for the random number generator used to inject failures into the execution. For a given instance of the scheduling problem, simulation results are obtained for different seeds, i.e., different failure traces.

Unless specified otherwise, analytical/simulation results are for $D{=}10^4$, $\lambda{=}10^{-3}$, $R{=}0$, $B_r{=}2$ GB/s, and $B_w{=}1$ GB/s.

V. One-PE Platform

With a single PE, only one task can execute at a time and rollback/recovery is the only way to cope with failures. For a single task, with fixed execution time and zero restart overhead, computing the probability of completion by a deadline is non-trivial as it requires characterizing the "longest gap" distribution of a Poisson process [24]. Furthermore, when considering a chain of tasks there is a continuum of possible values for the time remaining until the deadline at the next scheduling decision. To make the continuous-time scheduling problem tractable, we thus discretize time. For a given application, we use dynamic programming to precompute scheduling decisions in time polynomial in the number of discrete time intervals, and $O(1)$-time scheduling decisions at runtime.

A. Scheduling Strategy

Let time be discretized as a sequence of time steps of duration δ, so that all time durations are integral numbers of time steps. The execution time for execution mode j of task T_i, for x bytes of input data with error level y is then:

$$m_j^i = \left\lceil \frac{x/B_r + t_j^i(x,y) + d_j^i(x,y)/B_w}{\delta} \right\rceil,$$

where the numerator is the time to read the input, to perform the computation, and to write the output.

Let us consider an execution that conforms to a "first-output" policy by which a task is never re-executed once it has completed successfully once. This implies that the application execution stops as soon as one execution of task T_M has succeeded. Imposing this restriction makes the recursion hereafter more tractable and, more importantly, limits the state space size of the corresponding dynamic program.

We define $E(i,x,y,n)$ as the optimal expected error (with discretized time) when executing T_i to T_M for $i{=}1,\ldots,M$, where the input to T_i is x bytes with error level y, given that there are n time steps until the deadline. If $\forall j\ m_j^i{>}n$, then $E(i,x,y,n){=}e_f$, since there is no possibility of completing T_i by the deadline. Otherwise, recursively:

$$\begin{aligned} E(i,x,y,n) = \min_{1\le j\le K_i,\ s.t.\ m_j^i\le n} \Big[& \\ & e^{-\lambda m_j^i\delta} \times E(i+1, d_j^i(x,y), e_j^i(x,y), n-m_j^i) + \\ & \sum_{u=0}^{m_j^i-1} p_u E(i,x,y,\max(0, n-u-1-\lceil R/\delta\rceil))\Big], \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

where $p_u{=}e^{-\lambda u\delta}{-}e^{-\lambda(u+1)\delta}$, i.e., the probability that a failure occurs during time step u, where time step 0 is the first time step. The above expression is the minimum expected error over all feasible execution modes used for the upcoming execution of T_i. The first term is for the case in which there is no failure during the execution of T_i with execution mode j, which happens with probability $e^{-\lambda m_j^i\delta}$. In this case, the execution will proceed with T_{i+1}, with input data size and error level based on the output from T_i, and with m_j^i fewer time steps remaining until the deadline. The second term considers all time steps at which the execution of T_i can fail. Failing during time step u happens with probability p_u and will cause a re-execution of T_i but with $u{+}1{+}\lceil R/\delta\rceil$ fewer time steps until the deadline. The base case is simply $E(M+1,x,y,n) = y$.

The above recursion provides a dynamic programming solution for precomputing all scheduling decisions. The initial decision is to select an execution mode that attains the minimum in the expression for $E(1,x_0,y_0,H)$, where x_0 and y_0 are the size and error of the input to task T_1, and $H{=}\lfloor D/\delta\rfloor$. Note that the number of time steps until the deadline is rounded downward, while we round task execution times and restart overheads upward, so that an execution computed in

discretized time is guaranteed to be feasible in continuous time. Using memoization, all reachable values $E(i, x, y, n)$, together with the execution modes attaining their minima, can be precomputed and stored in a table. At runtime, whenever the PE is idle, the execution mode for the current state (i, x, y, n) can be selected in $O(1)$ time by looking up the table.

Let us denote by Q the number of possible size/error pairs for the input provided to all tasks, and let $K = \max_i K_i$. The time complexity for the above algorithm is $O(KQH^2)$, and the size of the computed table is $O(QH)$. The table could be compressed by storing, for each state (i, x, y), maximal intervals of values for which the selected mode is unchanged. Regardless, for a fixed application specification, the time and space complexities are pseudo-polynomial in the numerical deadline. Although Q may be exponential in the number of tasks, the algorithm remains practical (see results in the next section). Besides, for a given application and failure rate, the algorithm is invoked offline only once, and the computed table can be reused for all executions of the application.

Recall that the above approach is for a first-output policy. Due to the randomness of failures the application may complete well ahead of the deadline. A natural idea is then to use opportunistic *temporal redundancy* and attempt subsequent application executions. Integration of this idea in our recursion would require an enlarged state space. Instead, we perform temporal redundancy as a separate re-execution step after T_M completes. Each such re-execution is computed while excluding task mode sequences that cannot possibly improve on the error level achieved by the previously completed execution. It is straightforward to remove these execution modes from consideration and, provided any viable execution modes remain, apply our scheduling strategy again. The extent to which this temporal redundancy technique is useful depends on the application specification, the failure rate, the restart overhead, and the deadline. In our experimental results, when using this technique, we always restart the application from task T_1. Assuming that intermediate task output data from the previous execution are still available in stable storage, the re-attempted execution could start with task T_{i_0}, $i_0 > 1$. We leave investigating this possibility, including the problem of determining the best i_0, for future work.

B. Discretization Selection

A practical question is: what value of δ should be used? A smaller δ value yields a better approximation of the continuous-time problem, but leads to higher complexity due to a larger number of time steps. Although the algorithm needs to be invoked only once, a user could still wish to determine the largest value of δ that leads to accuracy within some tolerance.

The developments in the previous section actually compute a pessimistic upper bound on the optimal continuous-time expected error for the first-output policy. This is because the dynamic program is invoked for the deadline rounded downward, all task durations m_j^i are rounded upward, the restart overhead is rounded upward, and a failure at any point in a time interval "wastes" that entire interval. Small modifications make it possible to compute an optimistic lower bound: invoke the dynamic program for the deadline rounded upward; round all m_j^i task durations downward; and replace $n-u-1-\lceil R/\delta \rceil$ by $n-u-\lfloor R/\delta \rfloor$ in the recursive expressions. Note that for $u = 0$, if $\lfloor R/\delta \rfloor = 0$ there is a self-loop in the recursion. In this case we disregard the $u = 0$ term in the summation (and renormalize probabilities).

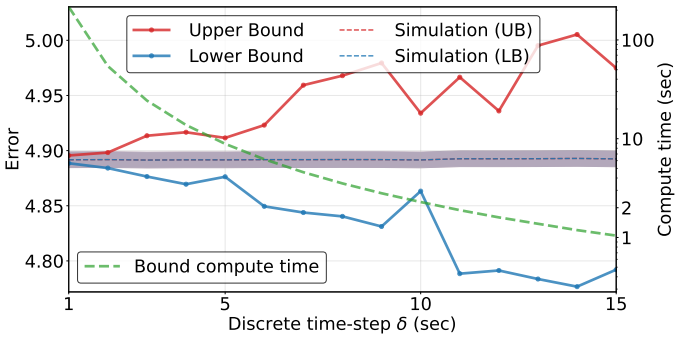


Fig. 2. Expected error bounds, sample simulated error for 5 million repeats (95% confidence interval shown by shaded region), and bound computation time vs. δ, for the fusion science use case in Section II.

In practice, a user would pick a value for δ so that the difference between the two bounds is below some threshold, and then make scheduling decisions according to the dynamic program for the lower bound or for the upper bound. For instance, Fig. 2 plots the two bounds vs. δ for the use case in Section II. As expected, the distance between the two bounds increases as δ increases. But the increase is not monotonic, as seen in the jagged shape of the curves. This behavior is easily explained by discretization effects. For instance, in the dynamic program for the upper bound, a task of duration t is considered to take time $\lceil t/\delta \rceil \times \delta$, which happens to be a non-monotonic function of δ. The plot also shows the time to compute the table (on a single 2.10 GHz core), using our implementation of the recursion in the previous section. The execution time decreases sharply as δ increases (the rightmost vertical axis is on a logarithmic scale). It is thus feasible to compute tight bounds relatively quickly. For instance, for δ=5, the computation time is ∼8.9s, and the distance between the two bounds is ∼0.72% of the upper bound.

We also wish to verify that our analytical bounds are consistent with our simulator's implementation. To this end, Fig. 2 also shows the simulated sample mean error and its 95% confidence interval, over 5 million trials, each for a different random seed (the simulator is executed in "model-consistent" mode, as described in Section IV). The simulated scheduling algorithm uses results produced by the dynamic program for the lower or for the upper bound (both results are shown but coincide almost exactly) to make scheduling decisions, without using temporal redundancy. Results in the figure confirm that the simulated sample mean error lies between the two bounds, and so does the confidence interval provided δ is large enough.

All results in the rest of this paper are obtained with δ=5. The above results show this value to be sufficient to achieve

high accuracy for our deadline $D{=}10^4$ (i.e., 2,000 discretized time steps). Recall that this is the deadline used in all our experiments, unless specified otherwise.

C. Platform Provisioning for Parallel Tasks

In practice, application tasks may be parallel programs that can be executed on n homogeneous compute nodes (e.g., an allocation/partition in a commodity cluster). In this section we consider n gang-scheduled compute nodes as a single PE that executes tasks one at a time and fails with rate $n{\times}\lambda_{node}$, where λ_{node} is the failure rate of a single node. (In Section VI, we consider the case of N independently schedulable PEs.)

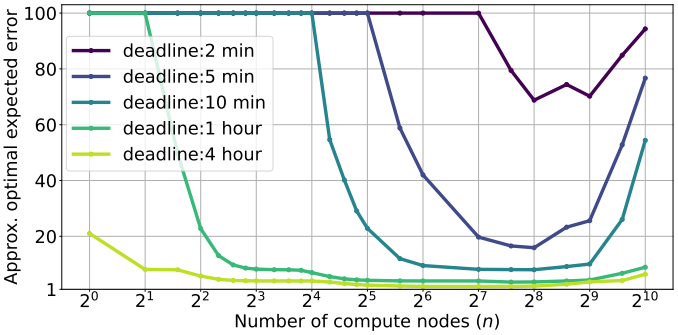


Fig. 3. Approximate optimal expected error vs. number of compute nodes for different deadlines, for the fusion use case in Section II.

Fig. 3 shows the approximate optimal expected error, as computed using the results in Section V-A, vs. n for our fusion science use case. Using a simple Amdahl parallel speedup model, the fraction of the sequential execution that is parallelizable is 0.89, 0.99, and 0.99 for tasks T_1, T_2, and T_3, respectively. These values are based on results in [12] and on information provided to us by the authors. As seen in the figure, the tighter the deadline, the more compute nodes are necessary to achieve an expected error below e_f (which is set to 100 in these experiments). For instance, doing so for a 5-minute deadline requires $n{>}32$ compute nodes. But using as many compute nodes as possible is not advisable because the failure rate increases with n. There is thus a "sweet spot" where n is large enough for parallelization to be useful but small enough that failures are not too frequent. Note that, for the shorter deadlines, the curves appear more jagged. This is because $\delta{=}5$ is larger relative to the deadline, leading to a coarser discretization (using a smaller δ value would yield more precise approximations of the optimal expected error for these shorter deadlines). Overall, such results allow a user to make informed decisions, e.g., select a value of n and a deadline that achieve a desirable compromise between hardware cost, timeliness, and expected error.

D. Evaluation of Simple Heuristics

Our dynamic programming approach is usable in practice. It also provides a reference against which heuristics can be compared and evaluated. This is useful to determine which scheduling principles are effective in the one-PE case, and may be worth reusing in the multi-PE case.

We consider four criteria for selecting a task's execution mode: (E) the lowest error level; (P) the highest probability of success by the deadline; (R) the highest ratio of probability of success to error level; and (X) the lowest expected error by the deadline. Criterion X criterion is computed using the recursion in Section V-A, while criteria P and R are computed using modified versions of that recursion. We then consider two categories of heuristics:

- **Nearsighted** (NS) - When selecting the execution mode for the next task using the chosen criterion, assume that this task is the last task in the chain.
- **Foresighted** (FS) - At the onset of the application execution, analyze each possible combination of execution modes for all tasks and select the combination that optimizes for the chosen criterion.

We denote each heuristic by its category and criterion, e.g., heuristic FS-X is the foresighted heuristic that uses the lowest-expected-error criterion. All these heuristics are static, i.e., once an execution mode has been decided for a task, that same mode is used for any re-executions of that task. Finally, we consider a baseline heuristic, RAND, that picks task execution modes randomly, for a total of $4{\times}2{+}1{=}9$ heuristics.

We evaluate our dynamic programming approach, which we denote by DYN, along with the above nine heuristics in simulation, for 500 different synthetic application configurations and 20 random trials per configuration. We use two different e_f multipliers, i.e., e_f is set to either $2\times$ or $5\times$ the highest possible error that a successful application execution can achieve. All findings and rankings hereafter are unchanged when considering results for different multiplier values separately, and we only discuss combined results. The use of temporal redundancy can only be beneficial, and our results show improvements in mean error ranging from 0% to 8.97% for all our heuristics, with an average improvement of 2.18%. In all that follows, we only discuss results with temporal redundancy enabled.

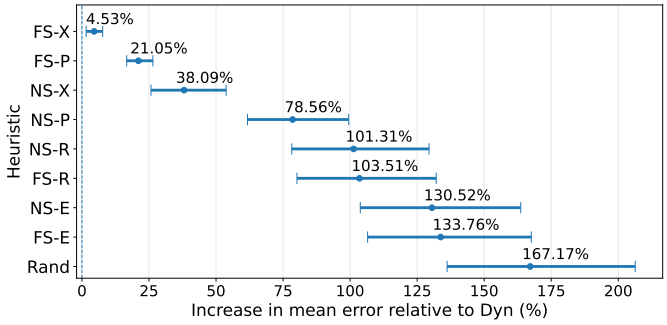


Fig. 4. Mean error increases relative to the dynamic programming approach in the one-PE case (95% paired-bootstrap confidence intervals shown).

We compare a heuristic H to DYN using the relative difference in expected error, $(\mu_H - \mu_{\text{DYN}})/\mu_{\text{DYN}}$, where μ denotes the achieved expected error. We estimate this quantity using the corresponding sample means and compute a 95% paired percentile-bootstrap confidence interval. Fig. 4 shows

these intervals for all heuristics. DYN outperforms all heuristics, since no confidence interval contains the value zero. As expected, RAND performs the worst. We find that among the four criteria, the ranking from best to worst is X (expected error), P (probability of success), R (probability of success to error level ratio), and E (error level). This is also expected because criterion X is the most directly related to the mean error objective, while criterion E, which comes last, is the least related. In terms of heuristic categories, for the bottom two criteria (R and E), the NS and FS versions perform similarly, with a small advantage to NS. However, for the top two criteria (X and P), the FS heuristic outperforms the NS version. This intuitively makes sense: the quality of the criterion magnifies the quality of longer-term planning.

Overall, the top-performing heuristic is FS-X (foresighted with the lowest expected error as the criterion), with a mean error increase of 4.53% relative to DYN. In our results, out of 20,000 experiments, FS-X and DYN tie in 11,584 cases, DYN wins in 7,106 cases and loses in 1,310 cases. DYN is not guaranteed to produce the lowest error for every particular failure trace: it minimizes expected error rather than the error for a particular realization of the failure process. To ascertain the sensitivity of the above results to the (number of) samples, we performed 500 random split-half analyses (keeping all experiments associated with the same application configuration in the same half). DYN ranked first and FS-X ranked second in 100% of the half-samples.

VI. MULTI-PE PLATFORM

In this section we consider a platform with $N>1$ independently schedulable PEs. A direct extension of the dynamic programming approach in the previous section would entail tracking the joint state of all task executions on all PEs. The state space is thus combinatorial in N (exponential with a straightforward representation), making the algorithm no longer pseudo-polynomial time (if N is considered part of the input). Even for fixed $N>1$, its time and space requirements would likely be prohibitive in practice. Proposition 1 establishes weak NP-hardness for the one-PE case. Whether a stronger complexity result is possible for the multi-PE case is an open question. Hereafter, we present several heuristics, some of which build on the one-PE dynamic program.

A. Heuristics

As in the one-PE case, we consider the DYN heuristic (which is executed independently at each PE) and the RAND heuristic. Section V-D describes eight one-PE heuristics: near-sighted (NS) vs. foresighted (FS), using one of four different criteria to select execution modes (E, P, R, X). We extend these heuristics to account for the simultaneous availability of all N PEs at time zero: given the $K\geq 1$ possible execution modes for T_1, the goal is to determine $n_1, n_2, \ldots, n_K$, where n_j is the number of PEs that will execute T_1 with mode j. We initially set all n_j's to zero and compute their values greedily. At each step, we consider the option of incrementing one of the n_j's (by one), leaving all others at their current value. Among these K options, we pick the one that leads to the best value of the scheduling criterion used by the heuristic. This process is repeated until $\sum_{j=1}^{K} n_j = N$. Hereafter we refer to these eight multi-PE heuristics as the "greedy" heuristics.

B. Temporal Redundancy

The design space for temporal redundancy is larger than in the one-PE case, and we consider three options:

- **Independent** (IND) – Use temporal redundancy independently at each PE whenever it becomes idle due to T_M completing successfully.
- **Dependent** (DEP) – When T_M completes successfully at a PE, all PEs whose current executions cannot possibly achieve a lower error (due to error levels achieved so far) abort their executions and apply temporal redundancy.
- **Aggressive** (AGG) – When T_M completes successfully at a PE, all other PEs abort their executions and apply temporal redundancy.

C. Reactive Rescheduling

With multiple PEs, there is an opportunity for *reactive rescheduling*: upon the completion of a task execution at a PE, other PEs can abort their ongoing task executions and perform new scheduling decisions. We consider three options:

- **Off** (OFF) – No reactive rescheduling.
- **Variant** (VAR) – Upon completion of task T_i at PE p, if the ongoing application execution at PE $q \neq p$ cannot achieve a lower overall error than the execution at PE p, then q aborts its execution. An application execution is then restarted on PE q, but starting at task T_{i+1}. The input data provided to task T_{i+1} is the output data from the execution of task T_i at PE p.
- **Aggressive** (AGG) – Upon completion of task T_i at PE p, all other PEs abort their ongoing application executions and restart their executions at task T_{i+1}. The input data provided to task T_{i+1} is the output data from the execution of task T_i at PE p.

D. Evaluation Methodology

We define a scheduling strategy as a combination of *design choices*, A/B/C, where A is the heuristic, B is the temporal redundancy scheme, and C is the reactive rescheduling scheme. Our goal is to determine which design choices, and combinations thereof, lead to effective scheduling strategies. To this end, we perform one-to-one comparisons between strategies that differ only in one particular design choice, holding all other design choices fixed.

We evaluate these strategies in simulation for 470 different synthetic application configurations and 25 random trials per configuration, for a platform with $N \in \{2, 4, 8, 16\}$ PEs. As in Section V-D we use $2\times$ and $5\times$ e_f multipliers. With $5\times$, there is a larger spread between the high- and low-performing strategies (due to a larger penalty for not meeting the deadline). But the conclusions drawn from our results and the ranking of the high-performing strategies when considering e_f multiplier values separately or combined are unchanged. Hereafter, we only discuss the combined results.

As in Section V-D, we compare two strategies X and Y using bootstrap confidence intervals of their relative differences in mean error. We say that Y *outperforms*, resp. *is outperformed* by, X when the interval is strictly positive, resp. negative. When the interval contains zero, we say that the two strategies tie. To quantify the sensitivity of our results to the (number of) samples, we performed 500 random split-half analyses. Overall, the top-performing strategy (see Section VI-G) is identical for 100%, 86%, 100%, and 100% of the half-samples, for N=2, 4, 8, and 16, respectively.

Regardless of N, strategies that use RAND are at best in the bottom 55% of strategies, and lead to mean error at least 3.52× larger and up to 7.72× larger than that of the best-performing strategy. We exclude RAND from all results hereafter, considering thus 8+1=9 heuristics for a total of 9×3×3=81 strategies.

E. Design Choices for the Greedy Heuristics

Is the multi-PE greedy extension useful? – Yes. We conduct experiments in which each of the eight one-PE heuristics is used independently at each PE. Each such heuristic, for any given temporal redundancy and reactive rescheduling scheme, is outperformed by or ties with its greedy counterpart. Out of 72 one-to-one comparisons (eight heuristics, three temporal redundancy schemes, three reactive rescheduling schemes), the one-PE version is outperformed in 17, 26, 24, and 24 of them for N=2, 4, 8, and 16, respectively, where all others are ties. The mean error improvement of the greedy version grows with N, from 3.6% on average for N=2 to 29.4% on average for N=16. Expectedly, considering all PEs jointly matters more as N grows. We consider only the greedy heuristics hereafter.

Is foresighted scheduling worthwhile? – Yes. Out of 36 one-to-one comparisons (four scheduling criteria, three temporal redundancy schemes, three reactive rescheduling schemes), FS outperforms NS in 27, 27, 27, and 21 of them for N=2, 4, 8, and 16, respectively, with NS leading to a mean error higher by 67.2% to 182.3% on average, depending on N. In the remaining comparisons, NS outperforms FS in 9, 3, 3, and 9 cases, with mean error lower by 1.9% to 14.4% on average, and the two tie otherwise. Hereafter, we only consider FS.

Which criteria should be used? – P is ineffective. Despite being the second best criterion for one PE (Section V-D), it is outperformed by X for every temporal redundancy/reactive rescheduling scheme. We surmise this is because, unlike the other criteria, it does not account for the magnitude of the error. Hereafter, we no longer consider it. The relative effectiveness of the other criteria depends on N:

- N≤4: X is best, then R, then E;
- N=8: R is best, then X, then E;
- N=16: E is best, then R, then X.

We find that X (the criterion most directly tied to the objective, and the best one for the one-PE case) should be used when resources are scarce, but one should use simpler criteria when resources are plentiful and failures are less of a concern.

Which temporal redundancy option is best? – DEP is best. DEP and IND perform almost identically. Out of 36 one-to-one comparisons (three scheduling criteria, three reactive rescheduling schemes, four N values), they tie 31 times, DEP outperforming IND with mean error lower by at most 0.01% for the other 5 comparisons. For each N value, DEP outperforms AGG in three of the nine one-to-one comparisons, AGG leading to mean error higher by 0.8%, 3.0%, 8.2%, and 22.3% on average for N = 2, 4, 8, and 16, respectively. AGG outperforms DEP for only one of the nine one-to-one comparisons for each N value, with mean error at most 1.4% lower. Overall, DEP is never outperformed by IND and outperforms AGG more often than it is outperformed by it (and when outperformed by it, it is only marginally so). This is because AGG can prematurely terminate executions that could produce good results, and because IND simply does not capitalize on the work accomplished by other PEs. Hereafter, we only consider DEP.

Should reactive rescheduling be used? – Yes, except perhaps for large N. For each of the three scheduling criteria, VAR and AGG perform nearly identically across all N values (relative differences in mean error at most 0.7%). For N≤8, OFF is outperformed by the other two options. For instance, AGG leads to mean error lower by 46.4%, 67.7%, and 66.8% on average for N=2, 4, and 8, respectively. For N=16, OFF is outperformed for two of the scheduling criteria (by 60.6% on average). However, for the X criterion, VAR and AGG lead to mean error higher than that of OFF by at least 103.5%. While this may seem surprising, with many PEs, there is a larger chance that a "too risky" execution path is "lucky" and completes a task relatively early. In this case, reactive rescheduling will cause all PEs to embark on that same path, whereas OFF ends up being a better, more risk-averse option. Overall, reactive rescheduling is beneficial when resources are scarce, but it could be detrimental as the number of PEs increases. Hereafter, we only consider AGG and OFF.

F. Design Choices for the DYN *Heuristic*

Should reactive rescheduling be used? – Yes, with AGG. We note that AGG is only slightly better than VAR: For each of the three temporal redundancy options and the four N values, AGG is never outperformed by VAR, and leads to mean error lower by at most 0.6%. OFF is always detrimental and never outperforms AGG. Recall that, for the greedy heuristics, OFF can be beneficial. This is not the case here because DYN better takes into account the time remaining until the deadline. AGG's mean error is lower than OFF's by 56.1%, 72.9%, 60.4%, and 29.4% on average for N=2, 4, 8, and 16, respectively. The error reduction eventually decreases with N, which is the same trend as for the greedy heuristics: as resources become more plentiful, reactive rescheduling becomes less useful (but not detrimental even at N=16). Hereafter, we only consider the AGG option.

Does the temporal redundancy option matter? – No. With AGG reactive rescheduling, all three temporal redundancy options yield identical results. This is because AGG reactive rescheduling essentially subsumes temporal redundancy. Hereafter, out of the nine possible strategies that use DYN, we

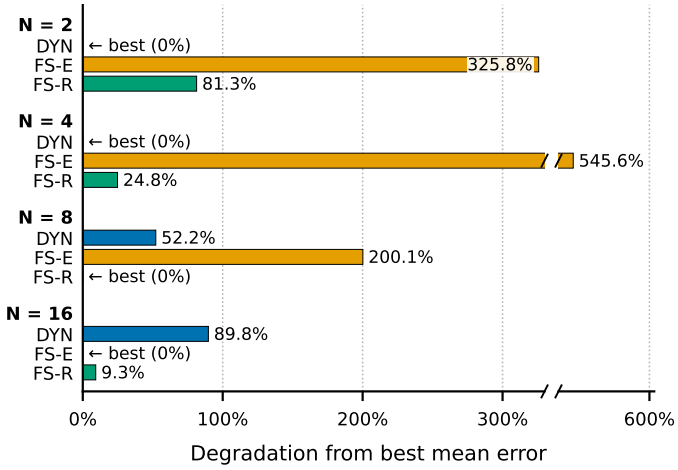


Fig. 5. Average degradation from best mean error vs. N for the heuristics used in the three non-dominated strategies.

only consider DYN/DEP/AGG (using the same DEP temporal redundancy option as for the greedy heuristics).

G. Which Heuristic for Which Regime?

The results in the two previous sections identify the scheduling strategy design choices that are effective. Excluding the choices that are ineffective leaves us with seven strategies. For each N value, we perform one-to-one comparisons and remove any strategy that is outperformed by any other. This process results in the same three non-dominated strategies for all N values: DYN/DEP/AGG, FS-E/DEP/AGG, and FS-R/DEP/AGG.

These three strategies all employ the DEP temporal redundancy scheme and the AGG reactive rescheduling scheme, but use three different heuristics. Fig. 5 shows the average percentage degradation from best mean error for the three heuristics. For $N \leq 4$, DYN outperforms its competitors by a significant margin (by more than 81% and 24% for $N=2$ and 4, respectively). In contrast, DYN loses by large margins for $N \geq 8$. For $N=8$, FS-R is the clear winner, with its competitors leading to mean error higher by more than 50%. For $N=16$, FS-E is the best heuristic, with FS-R a close second.

We conclude that DYN is more competitive when resources are scarce, i.e., when closer to the $N=1$ case. As N grows, it is increasingly important to account for all PEs jointly, which DYN does not do (as it is used independently at each PE). Consequently, for larger N, greedy heuristics, albeit less sophisticated in terms of local scheduling decisions, become more competitive than and outperform DYN.

VII. Optimal Strategies as a Markov Decision Process

Rewriting the recursion as a MDP so it can take into account rescheduling options including for things like temporal redundancy and reactive rescheduling.

A. One-PE Formulation

State – A state is a pair (C, n), where n is the number of time steps until the deadline and C is the set of all results reached so far. An element $(i, x, y) \in C$ denotes an input of x bytes and error level y available as input to task T_i. Initially $C = \{(1, x_0, y_0)\}$ and $n = H$. The output error so far is:

$$y_{\min}(C) = \min\left(e_f, \min_{(M+1,x,y)\in C} y\right).$$

Actions – At time zero and after each success or failure, execute any task T_i on any of its available inputs with any execution mode j, given that it can complete by the deadline and would produce a new output:

$$A(C,n) = \{(i,x,y,j) : (i,x,y) \in C, i \leq M, m_j^i \leq n, \\ (i+1, d_j^i(x,y), e_j^i(x,y)) \notin C\}.$$

Transitions – For action (i, x, y, j):

- **success, with probability** $e^{-\lambda m_j^i \delta}$ $(C \cup \{(i+1, d_j^i(x,y), e_j^i(x,y))\}, n - m_j^i)$
- **failure during time step** u**, with probability** p_u $(C, \max(0, n - u - 1 - \lceil R/\delta \rceil))$.

Optimal expected error – Let $E(C, n)$ be the optimal expected error from state (C, n). If $A(C, n) = \emptyset$ then $E(C, n) = y_{\min}(C)$. Otherwise:

$$E(C,n) = \min_{(i,x,y,j)\in A(C,n)} \Big[\\ e^{-\lambda m_j^i \delta} \times E(C \cup \{(i+1, d_j^i(x,y), e_j^i(x,y))\}, n - m_j^i) + \\ \sum_{u=0}^{m_j^i - 1} p_u E(C, \max(0, n - u - 1 - \lceil R/\delta \rceil))\Big].$$

The optimal expected error for the application is $E(\{(1, x_0, y_0)\}, H)$.

B. Multi-PE Formulation

State – A state is a triple (C, n, σ). Set C is shared by all PEs, and $\sigma = (\sigma_1, \ldots, \sigma_N)$ gives the possible statuses of each PE:

- available
- executing task T_i on input (x, y) with mode j
- restarting after a failure

VIII. Related Work

This work targets scenarios in which an application task can implement different trade-offs between execution time and output error, which is often termed *approximate computing* [25] and can be achieved with hardware or software techniques [4], [16]. Leveraging approximate computing for real-time applications is a natural idea [7], [26], which has been explored for various workload and application models [27]–[31] and remains an active area of research [2]. The scheduling of real-time, approximate computing applications, for both aperiodic and periodic scenarios, has been studied for transient errors, where the probability of error depends on DVFS levels [5], [6], and for fail-stop failures [7]–[10].

A popular approximate computing model is the *monotone* model [7]: each task consists of a mandatory portion that can produce output with some error, followed by an optional portion that incrementally reduces the error and can

be interrupted at any time. This monotone model is not applicable to the use case that motivates this work, as the level of approximation of a task must be decided at the onset of its (re)execution, at which point its execution time and output error level are fixed, and no usable intermediate output is produced. Instead of the monotone model, some works consider that each task comes with a primary mode (costly, low-error) and an alternate mode (cheap, high-error). For instance, the authors in [9] propose an approach in which the primary is always scheduled before the alternate. In this work, we consider tasks that can have arbitrary numbers of execution modes. A natural context in which tasks provide multiple execution modes is when different DVFS levels lead to different trade-offs between a task's execution time and the probability that its output is erroneous. In [5], the authors focus on periodic tasks with individual deadlines and seek to minimize energy consumption. In [6], the authors have a similar objective but, like in this work, consider an application with an end-to-end deadline. In both works, the objective is to minimize energy consumption while guaranteeing a particular reliability, i.e., bounding the probability that at least one task output is erroneous. In contrast, motivated by the use case in Section II, in this work some level of application output error is tolerable and we aim to minimize the expected error.

The work most closely related to ours is [11]. It considers deadline-constrained task chains subject to fail-stop failures, where task execution modes offer different trade-offs between execution time and output error. The authors formulate a static resource provisioning problem: determine optimal choices for the number of application replicas to execute concurrently, the execution modes for each replica, and the number of compute resources allocated to each replica, for a given resource budget. In contrast, we consider adaptive scheduling decisions throughout execution, including replication, rollback/recovery, mode changes after observed failures, reuse of persistent intermediate outputs, and coordination across PEs. These additional mechanisms require reasoning about the dynamic execution state rather than making a one-time resource provisioning decision. To the best of our knowledge, the adaptive scheduling problem in this work has not been studied previously.

IX. Conclusion

We have studied the problem of scheduling a chain of multi-mode tasks by an end-to-end deadline in the presence of fail-stop failures. Even a restricted version of this problem is NP-hard. In the one-PE case, dynamic programming makes it possible to precompute optimal scheduling decisions for a time-discretized version of the problem under a first-output execution policy. In the multi-PE case, we have proposed several heuristics. Using these heuristics in conjunction with temporal redundancy and reactive rescheduling schemes yields a set of scheduling strategies. Simulation results over a large set of application configurations show which scheduling strategy design choices are sound, yielding a small set of top-performing strategies with different relative effectiveness at different platform scales.

Our work can be extended in several ways. Our temporal redundancy approach could be extended to re-execute the application from a task T_i, $i > 1$, and/or could be integrated as part of the dynamic program (at the cost of a much larger state space). Our experimental results provide a basis upon which to develop more effective heuristics in the future, e.g., ones that combine our dynamic programming approach with our greedy heuristics. Another future work direction is to consider in-situ executions in which consecutive tasks are merged (to avoid I/O). Previously proposed task merging strategies for the purpose of makespan minimization [32] may be adapted to expected error minimization for multi-mode tasks. In the multi-PE case, when tasks are parallel programs, an interesting problem is to find a compromise between having each task use all PEs (as in Section V-C) and each task use a single PE (as in Section VI). Finally, a broader future direction is to go beyond chains and consider more general task graphs.

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